

LIFECYCLE EMAIL CAMPAIGN CASE STUDY

A Complete Lifecycle Email Marketing Strategy for *Airbnb Experiences*

Turning a booked stay into a lived-in story — a five-email nurture program that moves first-time travellers from Homes guest to Experiences guest.



Executive Summary

Why Experiences needs its own lifecycle voice inside the inbox, and what this program is designed to do about it.

Ⓢ THE CORE IDEA

Most travellers who book an Airbnb home never see Airbnb Experiences at all. They discover it, if ever, through a search results page they weren't looking at. This program treats the inbox as the highest-trust surface Airbnb owns post-booking, and uses it to introduce Experiences at the exact moments a traveller is already thinking about their trip — right after booking, mid-planning, and just before departure.

The strategy below is a five-email, behaviour-triggered sequence that begins the moment a guest confirms a Homes reservation and ends a few days before check-in. Each email has a single job: move the traveller one step closer to treating their trip as more than a place to sleep. The sequence is built on three ideas that recur throughout this document — **trust before transaction**, **relevance before reach**, and **the itinerary as the unit of marketing**, not the individual listing.

Rather than a single blast promoting "things to do," the program segments by destination, travel-party type, and prior engagement with Experiences, then personalises subject lines, hero imagery, and host stories accordingly. Success is measured less by open rate in isolation and more by the share of Homes bookers who add at least one Experience to their trip — the metric that actually reflects cross-sell health.

5

Automated, trigger-based emails spanning booking to check-in

3

Core personas segmented by travel intent and party type

6

A/B tests planned across subject lines, CTAs, and urgency framing

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The strategy unfolds in the same order a traveller would experience it — background, audience, strategy, then the five emails themselves.

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Campaign Background

About Airbnb Experiences, the business problem it creates, and what this campaign is trying to fix.

About Airbnb Experiences

Airbnb Experiences lets local hosts sell activities — a cooking class, a walking tour, a night hike — directly to travellers, independent of where they're staying. It sits inside the same app as Homes, but it behaves like a second product with its own discovery flow, its own trust signals, and its own habits to build. Since its 2016 launch, Experiences has gone through several iterations, most notably a pause and relaunch around the pandemic years, and today it functions as a smaller, curated marketplace layered on top of the much larger Homes business.

That layering is the opportunity. Airbnb already owns the traveller's attention at the exact moment they're planning a trip — the Homes booking flow. Experiences, by contrast, has to earn attention on its own, competing with TripAdvisor, Viator, and a destination's own tourism board. Email is one of the few channels where Airbnb can hand Experiences some of that borrowed attention for free.

The Business Challenge

The gap isn't awareness of Airbnb — it's awareness of **this part** of Airbnb. Guests who complete a Homes booking rarely see Experiences unless they go looking for it, and most don't, because nothing in the post-booking flow tells them to. The result is a marketplace with real supply (host-led activities in most major destinations) and a demand problem that has nothing to do with product quality and everything to do with sequencing: Experiences is introduced too late, too generically, or not at all.

Left alone, this produces a familiar marketplace pattern — hosts churn because bookings are inconsistent, and travellers who would have loved an Experience never learn one existed nearby. A lifecycle email program is a low-cost, high-leverage way to intervene, because it doesn't require new supply or new product surface area — only better timing and better storytelling around what already exists.

Campaign Objectives

01

Cross-sell awareness

Introduce Experiences to every Homes booker before they arrive, not after.

02

Trust transfer

Borrow the trust travellers already place in verified Hosts to de-risk trying Experiences.

03

Booking conversion

Turn browsing into at least one added Experience per trip, measured against a holdout group.

Target Audience

Three personas built from booking behaviour, not demographics — because in a marketplace, intent predicts conversion better than age or income.

The First-Time Explorer

PRIMARY

Booking their first or second Airbnb stay, usually solo or as a couple. Curious about the destination but wary of tourist traps and doesn't yet know Experiences sits inside the same app as their reservation.

Price-sensitive Culture-driven Mobile-first

The Repeat Urban Traveller

SECONDARY

Frequent short-stay guest, often blending work and leisure. Time-poor, wants something distinctive in a free evening, and books late and fast when the offer is well-targeted and frictionless.

Time-poor High frequency Convenience-led

The Intentional Family Planner

SECONDARY

Books weeks or months ahead, cross-checks reviews carefully, and plans each day of the trip. Higher average order value and more receptive to structured, kid-friendly or group activities if trust signals are strong.

Plans early Reviews-led Safety-conscious

A note on scope

Personas are built from public traveller-behaviour patterns and standard lifecycle-segmentation practice. They are illustrative composites for this portfolio exercise, not verified Airbnb research.

♥ Traveller Pain Points

- ⊕ **Generic tourist activities.** Guests can already find bus tours and landmark tickets everywhere; Experiences has to feel like the antidote, not another version of the same thing.
- ☆ **Low product awareness.** Many guests simply don't know Experiences exists inside the app they already use to book their stay.
- ✓ **Uncertain trust.** Booking an activity with an independent local host feels riskier than booking a listing with hundreds of Homes reviews behind it.
- 🕒 **Planning fatigue.** By the time trip planning starts in earnest, travellers are overwhelmed and default to whatever's easiest to find, not necessarily best.

Campaign Strategy

What we're saying, and why the same idea has to be said three different ways to three different travellers.

◎ Value Proposition

♥ ONE SENTENCE

A stay tells you where you slept. An Experience tells you who you met — Airbnb Experiences turns a booked address into a lived-in story, hosted by the people who actually know the place.

This framing matters because it positions Experiences against the traveller's memory of the trip, not against a competitor's activity listing. Nobody remembers the exact square footage of the apartment they stayed in; they remember the pasta-making class with a host named Marco. That emotional payoff is the actual product being sold, and the messaging framework below is built to keep the copy anchored to it rather than sliding into generic "things to do" language.

◎ Messaging Framework

Belonging

Local, not touristy

Every email leads with a person and a place, never a category list. Hosts are named; activities are specific.

Trust

Verified, reviewed

Ratings, review counts, and host credentials appear early enough to do their job before the ask.

Discovery

Curated, not exhaustive

Three to five options per email, never a full catalogue — curation is itself a trust signal.

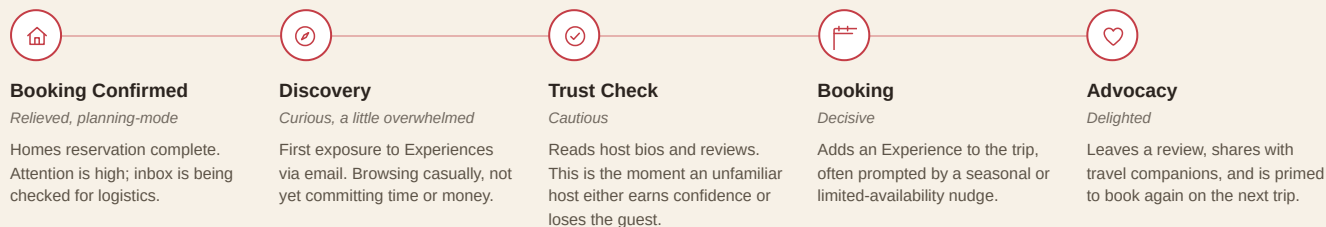
🚩 Tone & Voice

The sequence reads like a well-travelled friend forwarding a recommendation, not a marketplace pushing inventory. Sentences are short. Verbs do the work. Superlatives ("best," "must-see," "amazing") are avoided in favour of specifics — a host's name, a start time, what happens in the first ten minutes of the activity. Editorial restraint is itself part of the brand promise: if Experiences oversells the way a tourist brochure does, it undermines the exact trust it's trying to build.

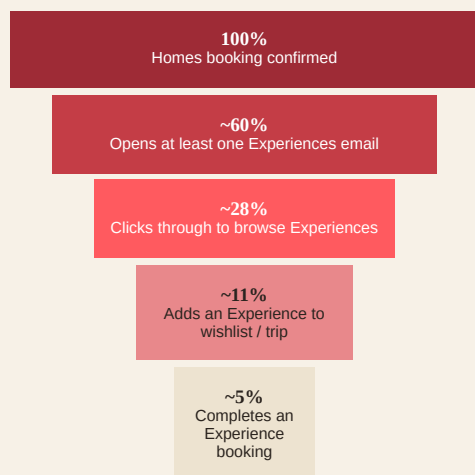
Customer Journey & Booking Funnel

How a traveller moves from confirming a stay to recommending an Experience to someone else.

Customer Journey Map



Booking Lifecycle Funnel



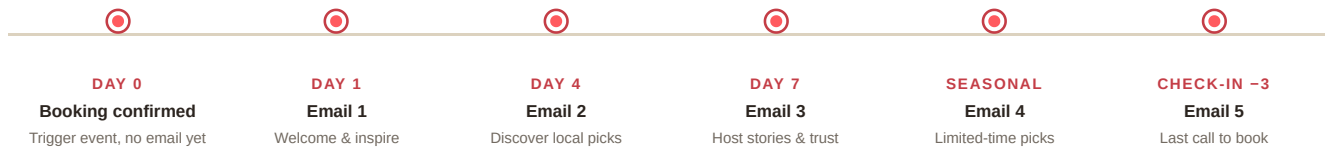
The steepest drop is between browsing and booking — the trust check stage. This is deliberate in the funnel design: Email 3 exists specifically to intervene at this point with host storytelling before Email 4 introduces urgency.

Figures are illustrative benchmarks informed by general email and marketplace conversion patterns (Mailchimp and Klaviyo industry benchmark reports), not disclosed Airbnb data. Used here to size the opportunity at each stage.

Campaign Timeline & Automation Workflow

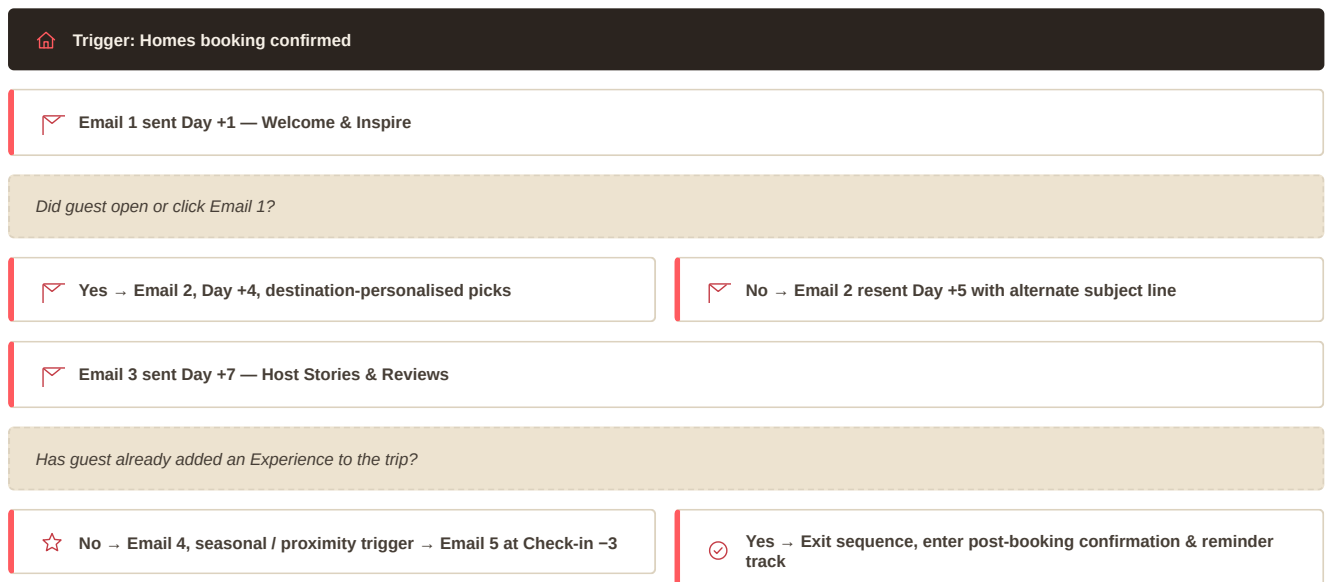
When each email fires, and the logic that decides who sees what next.

Campaign Timeline



Email 4 fires on a seasonal calendar or trip-proximity trigger rather than a fixed day, whichever comes first — see workflow below.

→ Email Automation Workflow



Email Campaign — Emails 1 & 2

Five emails, each doing one job. The first two open the door and hand the traveller a reason to keep looking.

Email 1 — Welcome & Inspire First-Time Travellers

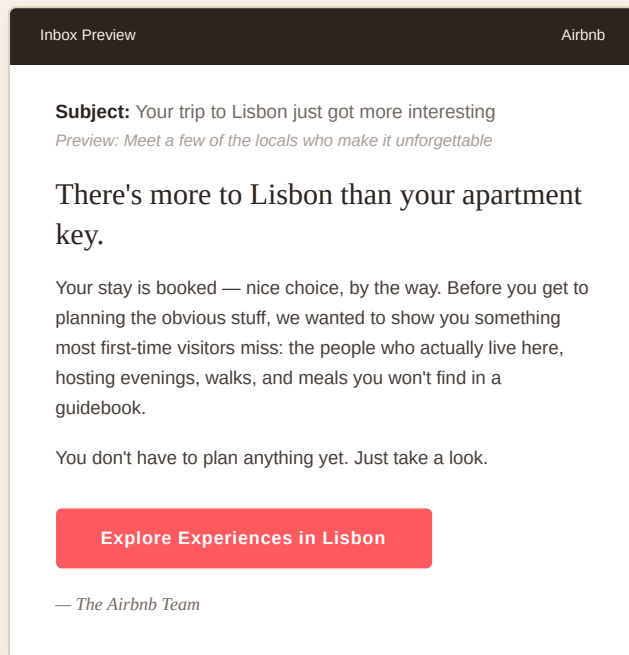
TOP OF FUNNEL · AWARENESS

01

OBJECTIVE Introduce Experiences right after booking

AUDIENCE All Homes bookers, first 3 stays

TRIGGER Homes booking confirmed, +24 hrs



PRIMARY CTA

"Explore Experiences in [Destination]" — links to a pre-filtered, curated list, not the full marketplace search.

EXPECTED BEHAVIOUR

Low-pressure open and skim. Success is a click-through, not a booking — this email exists to plant awareness early while intent is high.

Email 2 — Discover Unique Local Experiences

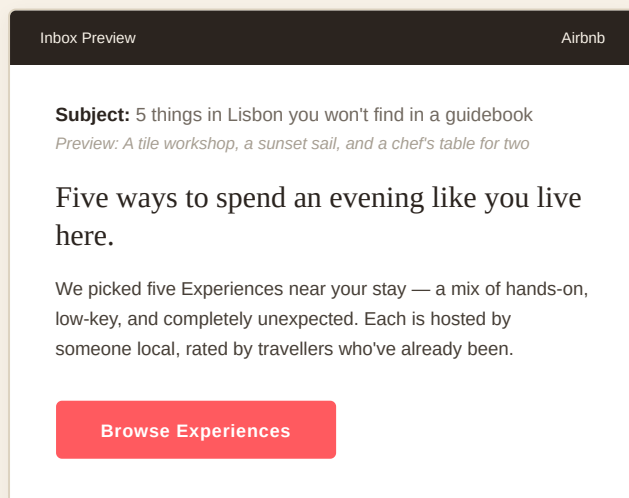
MID FUNNEL · CONSIDERATION

02

OBJECTIVE Move from awareness to active browsing

AUDIENCE Full segment, destination-personalised

TRIGGER Day +4, or +5 if Email 1 unopened



PERSONALISATION

The five picks rotate based on destination and, where known, party size — solo travellers see different defaults than families.

EXPECTED BEHAVIOUR

Higher click intent than Email 1. Guests begin comparing options; wishlist adds are the key signal to watch here.

Email Campaign — Emails 3 & 4

Trust does the heavy lifting before urgency ever enters the conversation.

Email 3 — Build Trust Through Host Stories and Reviews

MID FUNNEL · TRUST

03

OBJECTIVE De-risk booking with an unfamiliar host

AUDIENCE Openers/clickers from Email 1–2

TRIGGER Day +7

Inbox Preview

Airbnb

Subject: Meet Elena, who's shown 2,000 travellers her Lisbon

Preview: What her guests keep saying about that first hour

"I don't do tours. I show people my neighbourhood." — Elena

Elena has hosted her tile-and-tapas walk for six years. Her guests keep saying the same thing: it doesn't feel like a tour. It feels like being shown around by a friend who happens to know everyone.

[Read Host Stories](#)

WHY THIS WORKS

A named host with a specific, quoted detail outperforms a generic "highly rated hosts" claim — specificity is what makes trust transferable.

EXPECTED BEHAVIOUR

Longer dwell time on the email itself; clicks skew toward host profile pages rather than category browsing.

Email 4 — Limited-Time Seasonal Experience Recommendations

LOWER FUNNEL · URGENCY

04

OBJECTIVE Convert considered interest into a booking

AUDIENCE Engaged, not yet booked

TRIGGER Seasonal calendar or trip-date proximity

Inbox Preview

Airbnb

Subject: Only running through October: 4 Lisbon Experiences with real limited spots

Preview: Elena's tile walk has 3 spots left this month

Some of these only make sense this time of year.

A handful of Experiences near your stay are seasonal by nature — sunset sails before the weather turns, a rooftop dinner series that wraps up in October. Here's what's still available before your trip.

[Reserve Your Spot](#)

URGENCY, HONESTLY FRAMED

Scarcity claims are tied to real seasonal or capacity constraints, not manufactured countdowns — protects trust built in Email 3.

EXPECTED BEHAVIOUR

This email produces the highest booking-conversion rate in the sequence, precisely because trust was established beforehand.

Email 5, Segmentation & Personalisation

The last nudge before check-in, and the targeting logic that makes emails 1 through 5 feel personal rather than mass-sent.

Email 5 — Complete Your Booking and Create Lasting Memories

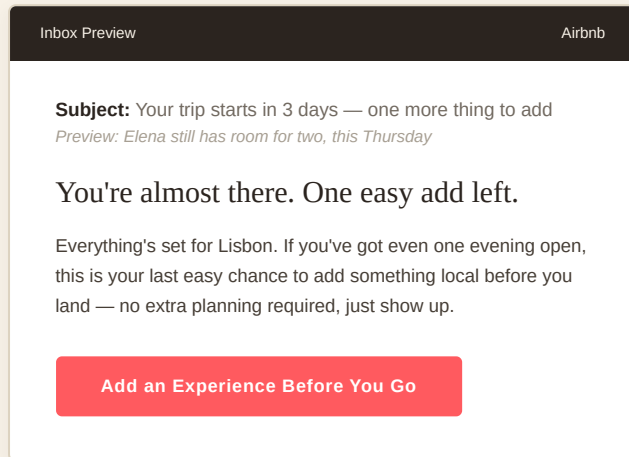
BOTTOM OF FUNNEL · CONVERSION

05

OBJECTIVE Final, low-friction chance to add an Experience

AUDIENCE No Experience booked yet

TRIGGER 3 days before check-in



BRANCH LOGIC

Guests who already booked an Experience skip this email entirely and instead receive a pre-trip reminder and checklist — protects against redundant, tone-deaf messaging.

EXPECTED BEHAVIOUR

Fast decision-making — this is a mobile, near-term click. Copy stays short and the CTA is the whole point.

⌘ Segmentation Strategy

Guests are segmented on five axes that update as the sequence runs: **destination**, **travel-party type** (solo, couple, family, group), **booking lead time**, **prior Experience history**, and **live engagement** with the sequence itself. A first-time solo traveller booking three weeks out receives a materially different Email 2 than a repeat family booker planning six months ahead — same automation, different content blocks.

© Personalisation Strategy

Beyond first-name tokens, personalisation runs through the destination-specific carousel of Experiences, host imagery matched to browsing category, and send-time optimisation based on each guest's historical open patterns. Guests with a prior Experience booking see a distinct track entirely — one built around repeat-host familiarity and faster-path CTAs, rather than the trust-building arc a first-timer needs.

A/B Testing Plan & KPI Dashboard

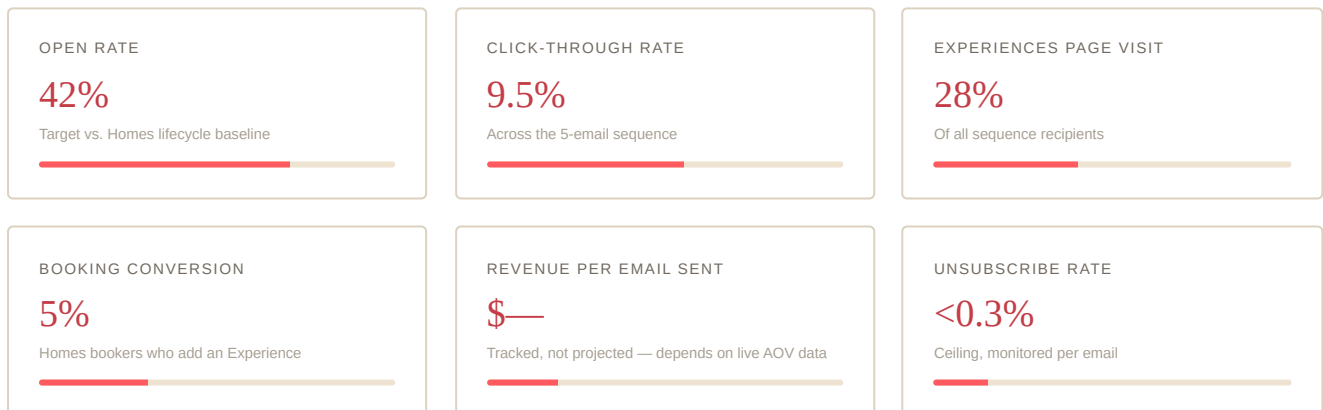
What we're testing first, and the metrics that tell us whether the sequence is working.

A/B Testing Plan

EMAIL	VARIABLE	VARIANT A	VARIANT B	PRIMARY METRIC
1	Subject line	Curiosity-driven ("just got more interesting")	Benefit-driven ("meet the locals who...")	Open rate
2	CTA copy	"Browse Experiences"	"See What's Nearby"	Click-through rate
3	Social proof placement	Host quote above the fold	Review count & rating above the fold	Click-to-host-profile rate
4	Urgency framing	"Limited spots" (capacity-based)	"Seasonal only" (time-based)	Booking conversion rate
5	CTA structure	Single CTA — "Add an Experience"	Dual CTA — "Book now" / "Save for later"	Booking rate & save rate

Each test runs on a minimum 2-week cycle per destination cohort, with statistical significance assessed before rolling a winner out sequence-wide.

KPI Dashboard



Targets are illustrative, directionally informed by published email marketing benchmarks (Mailchimp, Klaviyo). They are not official Airbnb performance figures.

Recommendations & Close

Where this program goes next, and what the exercise reinforced about lifecycle marketing in a two-sided marketplace.

Key Recommendations

- 1 **Expand the host storytelling library.** Email 3's performance depends entirely on having enough well-documented hosts per destination — this is a content pipeline problem before it is an email problem.
- 2 **Build a post-booking loop.** Guests who complete an Experience should re-enter a lighter, review-and-rebook sequence rather than exiting lifecycle marketing entirely.
- 3 **Test SMS or push for Email 4.** Time-sensitive, capacity-based urgency may convert better on a channel with faster attention than email.
- 4 **Deepen segmentation with in-app signals.** Browsing behaviour inside the app is a stronger personalisation input than booking metadata alone.
- 5 **Measure with a holdout group.** Last-click attribution will overstate email's role; a true incrementality test is the only way to know the sequence is actually driving bookings that wouldn't have happened anyway.

Professional Reflection

Building this sequence end to end was a useful reminder that lifecycle marketing in a marketplace is rarely about writing better emails in isolation — it's about finding the moment where trust, timing, and product visibility already intersect, and getting out of the way. The hardest design decision here wasn't the copy; it was sequencing the trust-building email before the urgency email, even though urgency alone would likely have produced a faster short-term lift. That trade-off, protecting long-term marketplace trust over a quicker conversion spike, is the kind of judgment call this exercise was meant to practise.

Conclusion

This is a small program with a specific job: make sure no Homes guest reaches check-in without knowing Experiences existed for their trip. Done well, it costs Airbnb almost nothing incremental and gives the Experiences marketplace exactly what it's been missing — a fair introduction, at the right moment, from a source the traveller already trusts.

References

COMPANY & PRODUCT

Airbnb Newsroom, news.airbnb.com · Airbnb Experiences, airbnb.com/s/experiences

INDUSTRY BENCHMARKS

Mailchimp Email Marketing Benchmarks & Statistics · Klaviyo Ecommerce Benchmark Report

FRAMEWORKS REFERENCED

Standard lifecycle-marketing and customer-journey-mapping practice as taught across CRM and growth marketing disciplines.

All figures presented as targets or benchmarks in this document are illustrative, composited for portfolio purposes, and are not confidential or proprietary Airbnb data.